

Kidney Transplant in Adults: What to Expect

Tell a health care provider about:

What are the risks?

What happens before?

What happens during a kidney transplant?

What happens after?

A kidney transplant is a surgery to receive a kidney from another person (donor kidney) when your kidney is causing problems or not working.

A donor kidney comes from a living person or from someone who has died (organ donor.) There may be a waiting list for the kidney donation, and treatment with a procedure that takes the place of the kidneys (dialysis) may be needed during the waiting period.

This procedure is a major surgery. A team of health care providers, called a transplant team, is needed to help the person prepare for the procedure and to help with recovery.

- Any allergies you have.
- All medicines you take. These include vitamins, herbs, eye drops, and creams.
- Any problems you or family members have had with anesthesia.
- Any bleeding problems you have.
- Any surgeries you have had.
- Any medical problems you have.
- Whether you're pregnant or may be pregnant.

Your health care provider will talk with you about risks. These may include:

- Possible short-term problems, such as:
 - Infection.
 - Bleeding.
 - Damage to nearby structures or organs.
 - Your body's defense system (immune system) attacking the new kidney. This is called rejection.
 - Pee blockage or leaking where the new kidney attaches to the bladder.
- Possible long-term problems, such as:
 - High blood pressure.
 - Blood clots in the blood vessels of the new kidney.
 - Narrowing of the blood vessels of the new kidney.
 - Emotional problems and stress. These may be caused by the long recovery and the need to limit contact with other people after the procedure.
 - Problems caused by medicines, such as an allergic reaction or a higher risk of infections, diabetes, certain cancers, and bone weakening.

When to stop eating and drinking

Eat and drink as you've been told. If you don't, your kidney transplant may be delayed or canceled. You may be told this:

- 8 hours before
 - Stop eating most foods. **Do not** eat meat, fried foods, or fatty foods.
 - Eat only light foods, such as toast or crackers.
 - All liquids are OK except energy drinks and alcohol.
- 6 hours before
 - Stop eating.
 - Drink only clear liquids, such as water, clear fruit juice, black coffee, plain tea, and sports drinks.
 - **Do not** drink energy drinks or alcohol.
- 2 hours before
 - Stop drinking all liquids.
 - You may be allowed to take medicines with small sips of water.

Medicines

- Ask about changing or stopping:
 - Any medicines you take.
 - Any vitamins, herbs, or supplements you take.
- **Do not** take aspirin or ibuprofen unless you're told to.

Surgery safety

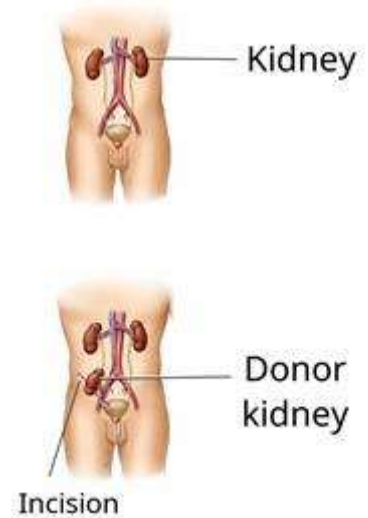
For your safety, you may:

- Need to wash your skin with a soap that kills germs.
- Get antibiotics.
- Have your surgery site marked.
- Have hair removed at the surgery site.

General instructions

- Tests may be done. This includes blood tests and imaging tests.
- **Do not** smoke, vape, or use nicotine or tobacco for at least 4 weeks before the surgery.
- You will need to plan for a long recovery time with limited activity. You may need psychological and emotional counseling to prepare for the procedure and long recovery.
- An IV will be put into a vein in your hand or arm.
- You may be given:
 - A sedative to help you relax.
 - Anesthesia to keep you from feeling pain.
- A small, soft tube will be inserted into your bladder (urinary catheter) to drain pee during and after surgery.
- A cut from surgery (incision) will be made in your lower belly (abdomen).

- The donor kidney will be placed in your belly.
- The surgeon will connect the blood vessels of the new kidney to the blood vessels inside the belly.
- The part of the body that drains urine from the new kidney to the bladder (ureter) will be sewn into the bladder.
- Usually, your old kidneys will be left in their normal position. The old kidney or kidneys may be removed if they are enlarged due to cysts or if they cause problems, such as high blood pressure or infections.
- A tube (surgical drain) may be placed near the new kidney to drain extra fluids from the surgical area.
- Your cut will be closed with stitches (sutures) or staples.
- Your cut will be covered with a bandage.



These steps may vary. Ask what you can expect.

- You'll be watched closely until you leave. This includes checking your pain level, blood pressure, heart rate, and breathing rate.
- You will have a breathing tube in their throat that is connected to a machine called a ventilator. While this tube is in place, you will be given a sedative to keep you asleep. If there are no early signs of bleeding or rejection of the kidney, the breathing tube will be removed.
- You may continue to have an IV that provides nutrition and fluids.
- Your IV may be removed after a few days when you can start eating your normal diet.
- You will be given medicines that help to relieve pain and prevent rejection of the new kidney.
- You may need to wear compression stockings to reduce swelling and help prevent blood clots in your legs.

This information is not intended to replace advice given to you by your health care provider. Make sure you discuss any questions you have with your health care provider.